

ADVANCED PHRASAL VERBS *for* IELTS SPEAKING

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About the Author



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He has helped over 40,000 students prepare for their IELTS Speaking test with his online courses.

Phrasal verbs are important in spoken English. They make you sound more natural and they are fun to use.

In this PDF, I will show you some advanced phrasal verbs to talk about many common situations you will find in IELTS Speaking.

These include;

- **Work**
- **Study**
- **People**
- **Places**
- **Events**
- **Activities**

1. WORK / STUDY

To knock off = to finish work

This phrasal verb actually has several different meanings, including;

To knock \$5 off a product = to reduce the price by \$5

To knock off someone – to murder (or kill) someone

The meaning I want to share with you related to work, is where it means ‘to finish work’, for example;

I knock off at 7pm = I finish work at 7pm

I’m knocking off early today, it’s Friday!

Learning Tip #1

When a word ends in a consonant sound and the next word starts with a vowel, we often link the two words.

Most prepositions start with a vowel, so most phrasal verbs can be linked.

For example, ‘**knock _off**’ can be pronounced as one word

/nɒkɒf/

Likewise in the past tense, ‘knocked_off’ can be pronounced as one word

/nɒktoʊf/

To chip in = to interrupt by adding a comment

You may know ‘chips’ as something you eat, but what about ‘chip in’?

Well, it means ‘to interrupt’, so we can use this in a meeting.

Imagine, there you are, in a meeting, listening to some colleagues ‘**rabbiting on**’ (talking non-stop about something boring), and you want to interrupt...

...so you can say,

Excuse me, can I just chip in?

We can also use this to talk about other peoples’ contributions in the meeting

He chipped in with some good ideas

**To hash out something = To talk about something with
someone in order to reach an agreement**

You probably know hashtag, right?

#SpeakEnglish

You may even know the food, made of potatoes, called 'hash browns'.

But, to 'hash out' has a different meaning.

It's used when you are talking to someone, discussing an idea, and trying to agree.

Let's see some examples.

We need to hash out the details of our presentation

My wife and I spent hours hashing out our holiday plans last night

2. PEOPLE

To wind someone up = to annoy someone

You have probably heard me say – ‘let’s wind up here’

When I come to the end of a class, and this means

Let’s wind up = let’s finish

However, ‘to wind someone up’ means to annoy or upset a person by doing or saying something.

Here are 2 examples,

She really winds me up when she says teachers have an easy life, she is so wrong!

I hate talking to Tom, he always winds me up

To make someone out = see, hear or understand something / someone

- I can’t make out your handwriting = it’s unclear and so I cannot understand it.
- I can’t make you out = I don’t understand your behaviour

Here is an example,

You say you want more space, then you say let's live together! I really can't **make you out!**

Learning Tip #2

When learning **vocabulary**, use a picture to help you remember the meaning.

For example, imagine two people discussing and trying to agree about what to do with a hash brown.

This image can help you remember the phrasal verb 'to hash out'

3. PLACES

To do up = decorate (a room, house, flat)

I have just **done up** the bathroom and it looks as good as new

**To drop in (on) to visit someone/place – usually without
planned invitation**

I am visiting New Delhi next week, I might **drop in** on you.
We could **drop in** on the pub on the way home after work.
Can I **drop in** on you tomorrow?

Other ways of saying 'to visit'

I **dropped in** on Jacob
I **went round** to Jacob's (house)
I **went over** to Jacob's
I **popped round** to Jacob's (U.K.)
I **popped over** to Jacob's (U.K.)

4. EVENTS

To turn out = to happen in a certain way

My presentation **turned out badly, I forgot everything**
That new recipe **turned out really well**

Be careful!

I turn out my presentation ❌

My presentation turns out ✅

To go off = to happen in a particular way (usually good)

The meeting **went off well**
My presentation **went off well**

Learning Tip #3

When learning new **vocabulary**, especially phrasal verbs, practice by making a phrase in the present and in the past!

This will help you memorise the word better, and build your **fluency** and flexibility.

Here is a simple template.

Usually ____, **but yesterday** ____

And here are some examples,

Usually, my presentations turn out well, **but yesterday**, it turned out badly.

Usually, my cooking turns out well, **but yesterday**, it turned out badly.

5. ACTIVITIES

You probably know 'to take up a hobby' but what about 'to take to' a hobby?

To take up (a hobby) = to begin

To take to (a hobby) = to enjoy a lot and do it well

My daughter started aikido recently and she **took to it** really well.
When I was younger I **took up** rock climbing and I **took to it** really quickly

To show off = to do something trying to show others how good you are (in an annoying way)

At school, the teacher's pet was always **showing off**.

To rub someone up the wrong way = to annoy someone (without intending to)

When the teacher's pet shows off, **it rubs me up the wrong way**

BONUS

My favourite phrasal verbs of all time!

I love this phrasal verb, partly because I love sleeping, but also because I just love the sound of it!

To nod off = To fall asleep

The meeting was so boring, I **nodded off**!

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